A STUDY GUIDE TO THE FOUR GOSPELS · KING JAMES VERSION

Red Letter

Thirteen studies in the words and works of Jesus Christ, with the Life of Christ in the four Gospels and a chapter-by-chapter reading checklist.

> But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.
>
> JOHN 20:31

The four Gospels

THE MAN

The Gospel According to St. Matthew

Jesus the promised King. Matthew shows again and again that Jesus fulfils what the prophets wrote. His Gospel gathers Jesus' teaching into five great sermons: the Sermon on the Mount (5–7), the sending of the Twelve (10), the parables of the kingdom (13), life in the community of disciples (18), and the end of the age (24–25).

Key verse, Matthew 5:17: Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil.

THE LION

The Gospel According to St. Mark

Jesus the Servant who acts with authority. The shortest and swiftest Gospel. Mark moves from scene to scene, and words like 'straightway' and 'immediately' appear again and again. The turning point is Peter's confession in chapter 8, after which Jesus sets His face toward the cross.

Key verse, Mark 10:45: For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

THE OX

The Gospel According to St. Luke

Jesus the Son of Man, Saviour of all. Luke is a careful historian. He gives special attention to the poor, to women, to outsiders, to prayer, and to the Holy Spirit. Many beloved parables are found only here: the Good Samaritan, the Prodigal Son, the Rich Man and Lazarus, the Pharisee and the Publican.

Key verse, Luke 19:10: For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.

THE EAGLE

The Gospel According to St. John

Jesus the eternal Son of God. John soars like an eagle. He records seven signs and seven 'I am' sayings, long conversations with Nicodemus and the woman at the well, and the intimate Upper Room teaching of chapters 13–17. About 90 percent of John is not found in the other three Gospels.

Key verse, John 20:31: But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

STUDY 1 · THE IDENTITY OF JESUS

Who Do You Say I Am?

Every other question in the Gospels turns on this one. Jesus asked His disciples directly, and the Gospel writers answer it from four angles: the eternal Word, the Son who forgives sins, the Christ confessed by Peter, and the risen Lord worshipped by Thomas.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 20:31

But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

1 The Word made flesh JOHN 1:1–5

> 1 In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.
> 2 The same was in the beginning with God. 3 All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made. 4 In him was life; and the life was the light of men. 5 And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not.

John opens before creation. The Word was with God and was God, and all things were made by Him. The Jesus of the Gospels did not begin at Bethlehem.

2 Full of grace and truth JOHN 1:14

> And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.

The eternal Word 'dwelt' among us. The Greek word means 'pitched His tent', an echo of the tabernacle where God's glory lived among Israel.

3 Authority to forgive MARK 2:5–12

> 5 When Jesus saw their faith, he said unto the sick of the palsy, Son, thy sins be forgiven thee. 6 But there were certain of the scribes sitting there, and reasoning in their hearts, 7 Why doth this *man* thus speak blasphemies? who can forgive sins but God only? 8 And immediately when Jesus perceived in his spirit that they so reasoned within themselves, he said unto them, Why reason ye these things in your hearts? 9 Whether is it easier to say to the sick of the palsy, *Thy* sins be forgiven thee; or to say, Arise, and take up thy bed, and walk? 10 But that ye may know that the Son of man hath power on

> earth to forgive sins, (he saith to the sick of the palsy,) [11] I say unto thee, Arise, and take up thy bed, and go thy way into thine house. [12] And immediately he arose, took up the bed, and went forth before them all; insomuch that they were all amazed, and glorified God, saying, We never saw it on this fashion.

The scribes were right that only God can forgive sins. Jesus does not correct their theology. He heals the man to prove He has that authority.

4 Peter's confession MATTHEW 16:13–17

> [13] When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, saying, Whom do men say that I the Son of man am? [14] And they said, Some *say that thou art* John the Baptist: some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets. [15] He saith unto them, But whom say ye that I am? [16] And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God. [17] And Jesus answered and said unto him, Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed *it* unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven.

Opinions about Jesus varied then as now. Peter's answer, 'the Christ, the Son of the living God', was not his own insight but a revelation from the Father.

5 The Father's voice MATTHEW 17:5

> While he yet spake, behold, a bright cloud overshadowed them: and behold a voice out of the cloud, which said, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased; hear ye him.

On the mountain the Father adds His own testimony and gives one command: hear Him.

6 One with the Father JOHN 10:30

> I and *my* Father are one.

His hearers understood this claim clearly enough to pick up stones (10:31-33).

7 My Lord and my God JOHN 20:27–29

> [27] Then saith he to Thomas, reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust *it* into my side: and be not faithless, but believing. [28] And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God. [29] Jesus saith unto him,

> Thomas, because thou hast seen me, thou hast believed: blessed *are* they that have not seen, and *yet* have believed.

The doubter makes the highest confession in the Gospels, and Jesus blesses all who will believe without seeing. That includes you.

For reflection

1. Which of these passages most changes how you picture Jesus? Why?

2. Jesus asked 'whom say ye that I am?' How would you answer Him today in your own words?

3. What does it mean for your daily life that the One who taught the Sermon on the Mount is also the eternal Word?

STUDY 2 · THE CHARACTER OF THE KINGDOM

The Beatitudes

Jesus opens His greatest sermon not with commands but with blessings. Each beatitude describes a person whom the world overlooks, and pronounces that person blessed. Read slowly. These eight sayings describe the heart God is forming in every disciple.

MEMORY VERSE · MATTHEW 5:8

Blessed *are* the pure in heart: for they shall see God.

1 The setting MATTHEW 5:1–2

> 1 And seeing the multitudes, he went up into a mountain: and when he was set, his disciples came unto him: 2 And he opened his mouth, and taught them, saying,

Like Moses at Sinai, Jesus goes up a mountain and teaches. He sits, as rabbis did, to give weighty instruction.

2 Poor in spirit MATTHEW 5:3

> Blessed *are* the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

The doorway into the kingdom is knowing we bring nothing. The kingdom belongs to the spiritually bankrupt who cry out for mercy.

3 They that mourn MATTHEW 5:4

> Blessed *are* they that mourn: for they shall be comforted.

Mourning over sin and over a broken world. Comfort comes to those honest enough to grieve.

4 The meek MATTHEW 5:5

> Blessed *are* the meek: for they shall inherit the earth.

Meekness is strength under God's control, not weakness. Jesus called Himself 'meek and lowly in heart' (11:29). Compare Psalm 37:11.

5 Hunger and thirst after righteousness MATTHEW 5:6

> Blessed *are* they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled.

A longing as basic as appetite: to be right with God and to see right done. This hunger is promised a full table.

6 The merciful MATTHEW 5:7

> Blessed *are* the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy.

Mercy received becomes mercy given. See the unforgiving servant in Matthew 18:21–35.

7 The pure in heart MATTHEW 5:8

> Blessed *are* the pure in heart: for they shall see God.

Purity here is an undivided heart, single in devotion. The reward is the highest of all: they shall see God.

8 The peacemakers MATTHEW 5:9

> Blessed *are* the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.

Not peace-keepers who avoid conflict, but peace-makers who reconcile. In this they resemble their Father.

9 Persecuted for righteousness' sake MATTHEW 5:10–12

> [10] Blessed *are* they which are persecuted for righteousness sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. [11] Blessed are ye, when *men* shall revile you, and persecute *you*, and shall say all manner of evil against you falsely, for my sake. [12] Rejoice, and be exceeding

> glad: for great *is* your reward in heaven: for so persecuted they the prophets which were before you.

The last beatitude returns to the first promise, the kingdom of heaven, and calls for joy under opposition.

10 Luke's sermon on the plain LUKE 6:20–23

> 20 And he lifted up his eyes on his disciples, and said, Blessed *be ye* poor: for yours is the kingdom of God. 21 Blessed *are ye* that hunger now: for ye shall be filled. Blessed *are ye* that weep now: for ye shall laugh. 22 Blessed are ye, when men shall hate you, and when they shall separate you *from their company*, and shall reproach *you*, and cast out your name as evil, for the Son of man's sake. 23 Rejoice ye in that day, and leap for joy: for, behold, your reward *is* great in heaven: for in the like manner did their fathers unto the prophets.

Luke records a parallel set of blessings, followed by woes (6:24-26). Notice how directly Jesus speaks: 'Blessed be ye poor.'

For reflection

1. Which beatitude describes where you are right now? Which one feels furthest from you?

2. How does Jesus' list of the 'blessed' differ from what our culture admires?

3. Where in your life is God calling you to be a peacemaker this week?

STUDY 3 · MATTHEW 5–7, THE KING'S MANIFESTO

The Sermon on the Mount

These three chapters are the longest unbroken teaching of Jesus in the Gospels. He takes the Law deeper than outward behaviour to the heart, teaches us how to pray, frees us from anxiety, and ends by asking whether we will build our lives on His words.

MEMORY VERSE · MATTHEW 7:24

Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock:

1 Salt and light MATTHEW 5:13–16

> 13 Ye are the salt of the earth: but if the salt have lost his savour, wherewith shall it be salted? it is thenceforth good for nothing, but to be cast out, and to be trodden under foot of men. 14 Ye are the light of the world. A city that is set on an hill cannot be hid. 15 Neither do men light a candle, and put it under a bushel, but on a candlestick; and it giveth light unto all that are in the house. 16 Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven.

Salt preserves and flavours; light reveals. Disciples are not told to become salt and light but that they already are.

2 The Law fulfilled MATTHEW 5:17–20

> 17 Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not come to destroy, but to fulfil. 18 For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled. 19 Whosoever therefore shall break one of these least commandments, and shall teach men so, he shall be called the least in the kingdom of heaven: but whosoever shall do and teach *them*, the same shall be called great in the kingdom of heaven. 20 For I say unto you, That except your righteousness shall exceed *the righteousness* of the scribes and Pharisees, ye shall in no case enter into the kingdom of heaven.

Jesus does not cancel the Old Testament. He fulfils it, and calls for a righteousness that goes beyond external rule-keeping.

3 Anger and reconciliation MATTHEW 5:21–24

> 21 Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not kill; and whosoever
> shall kill shall be in danger of the judgment: 22 But I say unto you, That whosoever is
> angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment: and
> whosoever shall say to his brother, Raca, shall be in danger of the council: but
> whosoever shall say, Thou fool, shall be in danger of hell fire. 23 Therefore if thou bring
> thy gift to the altar, and there rememberest that thy brother hath ought against thee;
> 24 Leave there thy gift before the altar, and go thy way; first be reconciled to thy brother,
> and then come and offer thy gift.

'But I say unto you.' Jesus traces murder back to its root in contempt. Reconciliation is more urgent than worship.

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4 Love your enemies MATTHEW 5:43–48

> 43 Ye have heard that it hath been said, Thou shalt love thy neighbour, and hate thine
> enemy. 44 But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to
> them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you;
> 45 That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for he maketh his sun
> to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust. 46 For
> if ye love them which love you, what reward have ye? do not even the publicans the
> same? 47 And if ye salute your brethren only, what do ye more *than others*? do not even
> the publicans so? 48 Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is
> perfect.

The Father sends rain on the just and unjust. Loving enemies is how children come to resemble their Father.

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5 In secret MATTHEW 6:1–6

> 1 Take heed that ye do not your alms before men, to be seen of them: otherwise ye have
> no reward of your Father which is in heaven. 2 Therefore when thou doest *thine* alms,
> do not sound a trumpet before thee, as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and in the
> streets, that they may have glory of men. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward.
> 3 But when thou doest alms, let not thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth:
> 4 That thine alms may be in secret: and thy Father which seeth in secret himself shall
> reward thee openly. 5 And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites *are*:
> for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that
> they may be seen of men. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward. 6 But thou,

> when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

Giving and praying are for an audience of One. The Father who sees in secret rewards openly.

6 The Lord's Prayer MATTHEW 6:9–15

> 9 After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. 10 Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. 11 Give us this day our daily bread. 12 And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. 13 And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen. 14 For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: 15 But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

Six petitions: three for God's glory (name, kingdom, will) and three for our needs (bread, forgiveness, deliverance).

7 Treasure in heaven MATTHEW 6:19–24

> 19 Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal: 20 But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal: 21 For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also. 22 The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light. 23 But if thine eye be evil, thy whole body shall be full of darkness. If therefore the light that is in thee be darkness, how great is that darkness! 24 No man can serve two masters: for either he will hate the one, and love the other; or else he will hold to the one, and despise the other. Ye cannot serve God and mammon.

Where your treasure is, your heart follows. Mammon (wealth) is a master that will not share.

8 Take no thought MATTHEW 6:25–34

> 25 Therefore I say unto you, Take no thought for your life, what ye shall eat, or what ye shall drink; nor yet for your body, what ye shall put on. Is not the life more than meat, and the body than raiment? 26 Behold the fowls of the air: for they sow not, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns; yet your heavenly Father feedeth them. Are ye not

> much better than they? 27 Which of you by taking thought can add one cubit unto his stature? 28 And why take ye thought for raiment? Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow; they toil not, neither do they spin: 29 And yet I say unto you, That even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these. 30 Wherefore, if God so clothe the grass of the field, which to day is, and to morrow is cast into the oven, *shall he* not much more *clothe* you, O ye of little faith? 31 Therefore take no thought, saying, What shall we eat? or, What shall we drink? or, Wherewithal shall we be clothed? 32 (For after all these things do the Gentiles seek:) for your heavenly Father knoweth that ye have need of all these things. 33 But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you. 34 Take therefore no thought for the morrow: for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself. Sufficient unto the day *is* the evil thereof.

'Take no thought' means 'do not be anxious'. Look at the birds and the lilies. Seek first the kingdom, and trust the Father for the rest.

9 Judge not MATTHEW 7:1–5

> 1 Judge not, that ye be not judged. 2 For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged: and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again. 3 And why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye? 4 Or how wilt thou say to thy brother, Let me pull out the mote out of thine eye; and, behold, a beam *is* in thine own eye? 5 Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye; and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother's eye.

Jesus forbids hypocritical, condemning judgment, not discernment. Deal with the beam in your own eye first.

10 Ask, seek, knock MATTHEW 7:7–12

> 7 Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you: 8 For every one that asketh receiveth; and he that seeketh findeth; and to him that knocketh it shall be opened. 9 Or what man is there of you, whom if his son ask bread, will he give him a stone? 10 Or if he ask a fish, will he give him a serpent? 11 If ye then, being evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children, how much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask him? 12 Therefore all things whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them: for this is the law and the prophets.

Persistent prayer to a good Father, followed by the Golden Rule as the summary of the Law and the Prophets.

11 Two gates, two trees, two builders MATTHEW 7:13–27

> 13 Enter ye in at the strait gate: for wide *is* the gate, and broad *is* the way, that leadeth to
> destruction, and many there be which go in thereat: 14 Because strait *is* the gate, and
> narrow *is* the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it. 15 Beware of
> false prophets, which come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravening
> wolves. 16 Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of
> thistles? 17 Even so every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree
> bringeth forth evil fruit. 18 A good tree cannot bring forth evil fruit, neither *can* a
> corrupt tree bring forth good fruit. 19 Every tree that bringeth not forth good fruit is
> hewn down, and cast into the fire. 20 Wherefore by their fruits ye shall know them.
> 21 Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven;
> but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven. 22 Many will say to me in
> that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name? and in thy name have cast
> out devils? and in thy name done many wonderful works? 23 And then will I profess
> unto them, I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity. 24 Therefore
> whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise
> man, which built his house upon a rock: 25 And the rain descended, and the floods
> came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded
> upon a rock. 26 And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not,
> shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand: 27 And the
> rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house;
> and it fell: and great was the fall of it.

The sermon closes with a choice. Hearing is not enough. The wise man hears and does.

12 With authority MATTHEW 7:28–29

> 28 And it came to pass, when Jesus had ended these sayings, the people were astonished
> at his doctrine: 29 For he taught them as *one* having authority, and not as the scribes.

The people were astonished. Jesus did not quote other rabbis. He spoke as the Lawgiver Himself.

For reflection

1. Which section of the sermon is hardest for you to obey? Ask the Lord for grace in that area.

2. Jesus repeatedly says 'Ye have heard… but I say unto you.' What does that reveal about who He is?

3. Read the Lord's Prayer slowly, one line at a time. Which petition do you most need to pray today?

4. What is one specific way you can 'hear and do' this week?

STUDY 4 · EARTHLY STORIES WITH HEAVENLY MEANING

The Parables

About a third of Jesus' recorded teaching comes in parables. He took seeds, coins, sheep, servants and wedding feasts and made them windows into the kingdom of God. Parables reveal truth to the willing and conceal it from the hard of heart (Matt 13:10-17). Here are twenty-four of them.

MEMORY VERSE · MATTHEW 13:9

Who hath ears to hear, let him hear.

1 Why parables? MATTHEW 13:10–17

> 10 And the disciples came, and said unto him, Why speakest thou unto them in parables? 11 He answered and said unto them, Because it is given unto you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it is not given. 12 For whosoever hath, to him shall be given, and he shall have more abundance: but whosoever hath not, from him shall be taken away even that he hath. 13 Therefore speak I to them in parables: because they seeing see not; and hearing they hear not, neither do they understand. 14 And in them is fulfilled the prophecy of Esaias, which saith, By hearing ye shall hear, and shall not understand; and seeing ye shall see, and shall not perceive: 15 For this people's heart is waxed gross, and *their* ears are dull of hearing, and their eyes they have closed; lest at any time they should see with *their* eyes, and hear with *their* ears, and should understand with *their* heart, and should be converted, and I should heal them. 16 But blessed *are* your eyes, for they see: and your ears, for they hear. 17 For verily I say unto you, That many prophets and righteous *men* have desired to see *those things* which ye see, and have not seen *them;* and to hear *those things* which ye hear, and have not heard *them* .

Parables are both a gift and a test. Those who lean in are given more.

2 The Sower MATTHEW 13:3–9

> 3 And he spake many things unto them in parables, saying, Behold, a sower went forth to sow; 4 And when he sowed, some *seeds* fell by the way side, and the fowls came and devoured them up: 5 Some fell upon stony places, where they had not much earth: and forthwith they sprung up, because they had no deepness of earth: 6 And when the sun was up, they were scorched; and because they had no root, they withered away. 7 And

> some fell among thorns; and the thorns sprung up, and choked them: [8] But other fell into good ground, and brought forth fruit, some an hundredfold, some sixtyfold, some thirtyfold. [9] Who hath ears to hear, let him hear.

Jesus explains it Himself in 13:18-23. One seed, four soils. The question is what kind of ground your heart is.

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3 The Wheat and the Tares MATTHEW 13:24–30

> [24] Another parable put he forth unto them, saying, The kingdom of heaven is likened unto a man which sowed good seed in his field: [25] But while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went his way. [26] But when the blade was sprung up, and brought forth fruit, then appeared the tares also. [27] So the servants of the householder came and said unto him, Sir, didst not thou sow good seed in thy field? from whence then hath it tares? [28] He said unto them, An enemy hath done this. The servants said unto him, Wilt thou then that we go and gather them up? [29] But he said, Nay; lest while ye gather up the tares, ye root up also the wheat with them. [30] Let both grow together until the harvest: and in the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, Gather ye together first the tares, and bind them in bundles to burn them: but gather the wheat into my barn.

Good and evil grow together until the harvest. Judgment belongs to the Lord of the harvest (explained in 13:36-43).

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4 The Mustard Seed and the Leaven MATTHEW 13:31–33

> [31] Another parable put he forth unto them, saying, The kingdom of heaven is like to a grain of mustard seed, which a man took, and sowed in his field: [32] Which indeed is the least of all seeds: but when it is grown, it is the greatest among herbs, and becometh a tree, so that the birds of the air come and lodge in the branches thereof. [33] Another parable spake he unto them; The kingdom of heaven is like unto leaven, which a woman took, and hid in three measures of meal, till the whole was leavened.

The kingdom starts small and hidden but grows to fill everything.

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5 The Hidden Treasure and the Pearl MATTHEW 13:44–46

> [44] Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto treasure hid in a field; the which when a man hath found, he hideth, and for joy thereof goeth and selleth all that he hath, and buyeth that field. [45] Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a merchant man, seeking

goodly pearls: 46 Who, when he had found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had, and bought it.

Both men sell everything with joy. The kingdom is worth more than all we have.

6 The Drag Net MATTHEW 13:47–50

47 Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a net, that was cast into the sea, and gathered of every kind: 48 Which, when it was full, they drew to shore, and sat down, and gathered the good into vessels, but cast the bad away. 49 So shall it be at the end of the world: the angels shall come forth, and sever the wicked from among the just, 50 And shall cast them into the furnace of fire: there shall be wailing and gnashing of teeth.

A final separation is coming.

7 The Seed Growing Secretly MARK 4:26–29

26 And he said, So is the kingdom of God, as if a man should cast seed into the ground; 27 And should sleep, and rise night and day, and the seed should spring and grow up, he knoweth not how. 28 For the earth bringeth forth fruit of herself; first the blade, then the ear, after that the full corn in the ear. 29 But when the fruit is brought forth, immediately he putteth in the sickle, because the harvest is come.

Found only in Mark. The sower sleeps and the seed grows 'he knoweth not how'. God gives the growth.

8 The Unforgiving Servant MATTHEW 18:23–35

23 Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants. 24 And when he had begun to reckon, one was brought unto him, which owed him ten thousand talents. 25 But forasmuch as he had not to pay, his lord commanded him to be sold, and his wife, and children, and all that he had, and payment to be made. 26 The servant therefore fell down, and worshipped him, saying, Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. 27 Then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt. 28 But the same servant went out, and found one of his fellowservants, which owed him an hundred pence: and he laid hands on him, and took *him* by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest. 29 And his fellowservant fell down at his feet, and besought him, saying, Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. 30 And he would not: but went and cast him

into prison, till he should pay the debt. 31 So when his fellowservants saw what was done, they were very sorry, and came and told unto their lord all that was done. 32 Then his lord, after that he had called him, said unto him, O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: 33 Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellowservant, even as I had pity on thee? 34 And his lord was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. 35 So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.

Ten thousand talents was an unpayable debt. Those forgiven so much must forgive.

9 The Labourers in the Vineyard MATTHEW 20:1–16

1 For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man *that is* an householder, which went out early in the morning to hire labourers into his vineyard. 2 And when he had agreed with the labourers for a penny a day, he sent them into his vineyard. 3 And he went out about the third hour, and saw others standing idle in the marketplace, 4 And said unto them; Go ye also into the vineyard, and whatsoever is right I will give you. And they went their way. 5 Again he went out about the sixth and ninth hour, and did likewise. 6 And about the eleventh hour he went out, and found others standing idle, and saith unto them, Why stand ye here all the day idle? 7 They say unto him, Because no man hath hired us. He saith unto them, Go ye also into the vineyard; and whatsoever is right, *that* shall ye receive. 8 So when even was come, the lord of the vineyard saith unto his steward, Call the labourers, and give them *their* hire, beginning from the last unto the first. 9 And when they came that *were hired* about the eleventh hour, they received every man a penny. 10 But when the first came, they supposed that they should have received more; and they likewise received every man a penny. 11 And when they had received it, they murmured against the goodman of the house, 12 Saying, These last have wrought *but* one hour, and thou hast made them equal unto us, which have borne the burden and heat of the day. 13 But he answered one of them, and said, Friend, I do thee no wrong: didst not thou agree with me for a penny? 14 Take *that* thine *is*, and go thy way: I will give unto this last, even as unto thee. 15 Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own? Is thine eye evil, because I am good? 16 So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen.

Grace is not wages. The landowner is generous, and the first are invited to rejoice rather than grumble.

10 The Two Sons MATTHEW 21:28–32

28 But what think ye? A *certain* man had two sons; and he came to the first, and said,
Son, go work to day in my vineyard. 29 He answered and said, I will not: but afterward
he repented, and went. 30 And he came to the second, and said likewise. And he
answered and said, I *go*, sir: and went not. 31 Whether of them twain did the will of *his*
father? They say unto him, The first. Jesus saith unto them, Verily I say unto you, That
the publicans and the harlots go into the kingdom of God before you. 32 For John came
unto you in the way of righteousness, and ye believed him not: but the publicans and
the harlots believed him: and ye, when ye had seen *it*, repented not afterward, that ye
might believe him.

What counts is not the polite answer but the obedience that follows.

11 The Wicked Husbandmen MATTHEW 21:33–44

33 Hear another parable: There was a certain householder, which planted a vineyard,
and hedged it round about, and digged a winepress in it, and built a tower, and let it out
to husbandmen, and went into a far country: 34 And when the time of the fruit drew
near, he sent his servants to the husbandmen, that they might receive the fruits of it.
35 And the husbandmen took his servants, and beat one, and killed another, and stoned
another. 36 Again, he sent other servants more than the first: and they did unto them
likewise. 37 But last of all he sent unto them his son, saying, They will reverence my son.
38 But when the husbandmen saw the son, they said among themselves, This is the heir;
come, let us kill him, and let us seize on his inheritance. 39 And they caught him, and
cast *him* out of the vineyard, and slew *him*. 40 When the lord therefore of the vineyard
cometh, what will he do unto those husbandmen? 41 They say unto him, He will
miserably destroy those wicked men, and will let out *his* vineyard unto other
husbandmen, which shall render him the fruits in their seasons. 42 Jesus saith unto
them, Did ye never read in the scriptures, The stone which the builders rejected, the
same is become the head of the corner: this is the Lord's doing, and it is marvellous in
our eyes? 43 Therefore say I unto you, The kingdom of God shall be taken from you, and
given to a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof. 44 And whosoever shall fall on this
stone shall be broken: but on whomsoever it shall fall, it will grind him to powder.

A parable of Israel's history ending with the Son Himself, the stone the builders rejected.

12 The Marriage Feast MATTHEW 22:1–14

1 And Jesus answered and spake unto them again by parables, and said, 2 The kingdom
of heaven is like unto a certain king, which made a marriage for his son, 3 And sent
forth his servants to call them that were bidden to the wedding: and they would not
come. 4 Again, he sent forth other servants, saying, Tell them which are bidden,
Behold, I have prepared my dinner: my oxen and *my* fatlings *are* killed, and all things
are ready: come unto the marriage. 5 But they made light of *it*, and went their ways, one
to his farm, another to his merchandise: 6 And the remnant took his servants, and
entreated *them* spitefully, and slew *them*. 7 But when the king heard *thereof*, he was
wroth: and he sent forth his armies, and destroyed those murderers, and burned up
their city. 8 Then saith he to his servants, The wedding is ready, but they which were
bidden were not worthy. 9 Go ye therefore into the highways, and as many as ye shall
find, bid to the marriage. 10 So those servants went out into the highways, and gathered
together all as many as they found, both bad and good: and the wedding was furnished
with guests. 11 And when the king came in to see the guests, he saw there a man which
had not on a wedding garment: 12 And he saith unto him, Friend, how camest thou in
hither not having a wedding garment? And he was speechless. 13 Then said the king to
the servants, Bind him hand and foot, and take him away, and cast *him* into outer
darkness; there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth. 14 For many are called, but few
are chosen.

The invited refuse; the streets are filled. Yet the guest must come on the King's terms.

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13 The Ten Virgins MATTHEW 25:1–13

1 Then shall the kingdom of heaven be likened unto ten virgins, which took their lamps,
and went forth to meet the bridegroom. 2 And five of them were wise, and five *were*
foolish. 3 They that *were* foolish took their lamps, and took no oil with them: 4 But the
wise took oil in their vessels with their lamps. 5 While the bridegroom tarried, they all
slumbered and slept. 6 And at midnight there was a cry made, Behold, the bridegroom
cometh; go ye out to meet him. 7 Then all those virgins arose, and trimmed their lamps.
8 And the foolish said unto the wise, Give us of your oil; for our lamps are gone out.
9 But the wise answered, saying, *Not so*; lest there be not enough for us and you: but go
ye rather to them that sell, and buy for yourselves. 10 And while they went to buy, the
bridegroom came; and they that were ready went in with him to the marriage: and the
door was shut. 11 Afterward came also the other virgins, saying, Lord, Lord, open to us.
12 But he answered and said, Verily I say unto you, I know you not. 13 Watch therefore,
for ye know neither the day nor the hour wherein the Son of man cometh.

Readiness cannot be borrowed at the last minute. Watch.

14 The Talents MATTHEW 25:14–30

> 14 For *the kingdom of heaven is* as a man travelling into a far country, *who* called his own servants, and delivered unto them his goods. 15 And unto one he gave five talents, to another two, and to another one; to every man according to his several ability; and straightway took his journey. 16 Then he that had received the five talents went and traded with the same, and made *them* other five talents. 17 And likewise he that *had received* two, he also gained other two. 18 But he that had received one went and digged in the earth, and hid his lord's money. 19 After a long time the lord of those servants cometh, and reckoneth with them. 20 And so he that had received five talents came and brought other five talents, saying, Lord, thou deliveredst unto me five talents: behold, I have gained beside them five talents more. 21 His lord said unto him, Well done, *thou* good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of thy lord. 22 He also that had received two talents came and said, Lord, thou deliveredst unto me two talents: behold, I have gained two other talents beside them. 23 His lord said unto him, Well done, good and faithful servant; thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of thy lord. 24 Then he which had received the one talent came and said, Lord, I knew thee that thou art an hard man, reaping where thou hast not sown, and gathering where thou hast not strawed: 25 And I was afraid, and went and hid thy talent in the earth: lo, *there* thou hast *that is* thine. 26 His lord answered and said unto him, *Thou* wicked and slothful servant, thou knewest that I reap where I sowed not, and gather where I have not strawed: 27 Thou oughtest therefore to have put my money to the exchangers, and *then* at my coming I should have received mine own with usury. 28 Take therefore the talent from him, and give *it* unto him which hath ten talents. 29 For unto every one that hath shall be given, and he shall have abundance: but from him that hath not shall be taken away even that which he hath. 30 And cast ye the unprofitable servant into outer darkness: there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

What we have been entrusted with is meant to be invested for the Master, not buried out of fear.

15 The Good Samaritan LUKE 10:30–37

> 30 And Jesus answering said, A certain *man* went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, which stripped him of his raiment, and wounded *him*, and departed, leaving *him* half dead. 31 And by chance there came down a certain priest that

way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. 32 And likewise a Levite, when he was at the place, came and looked *on him*, and passed by on the other side. 33 But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had compassion *on him*, 34 And went to *him*, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him. 35 And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave *them* to the host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee. 36 Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves? 37 And he said, He that shewed mercy on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise.

Asked 'who is my neighbour?', Jesus answers a different question: to whom will you be a neighbour?

16 The Friend at Midnight LUKE 11:5–10

5 And he said unto them, Which of you shall have a friend, and shall go unto him at midnight, and say unto him, Friend, lend me three loaves; 6 For a friend of mine in his journey is come to me, and I have nothing to set before him? 7 And he from within shall answer and say, Trouble me not: the door is now shut, and my children are with me in bed; I cannot rise and give thee. 8 I say unto you, Though he will not rise and give him, because he is his friend, yet because of his importunity he will rise and give him as many as he needeth. 9 And I say unto you, Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you. 10 For every one that asketh receiveth; and he that seeketh findeth; and to him that knocketh it shall be opened.

If a reluctant friend will get up for persistence, how much more will a willing Father give.

17 The Rich Fool LUKE 12:16–21

16 And he spake a parable unto them, saying, The ground of a certain rich man brought forth plentifully: 17 And he thought within himself, saying, What shall I do, because I have no room where to bestow my fruits? 18 And he said, This will I do: I will pull down my barns, and build greater; and there will I bestow all my fruits and my goods. 19 And I will say to my soul, Soul, thou hast much goods laid up for many years; take thine ease, eat, drink, *and* be merry. 20 But God said unto him, *Thou* fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee: then whose shall those things be, which thou hast provided? 21 So *is* he that layeth up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God.

He planned everything except eternity. Be rich toward God.

18 The Great Supper LUKE 14:16–24

> 16 Then said he unto him, A certain man made a great supper, and bade many: 17 And sent his servant at supper time to say to them that were bidden, Come; for all things are now ready. 18 And they all with one *consent* began to make excuse. The first said unto him, I have bought a piece of ground, and I must needs go and see it: I pray thee have me excused. 19 And another said, I have bought five yoke of oxen, and I go to prove them: I pray thee have me excused. 20 And another said, I have married a wife, and therefore I cannot come. 21 So that servant came, and shewed his lord these things. Then the master of the house being angry said to his servant, Go out quickly into the streets and lanes of the city, and bring in hither the poor, and the maimed, and the halt, and the blind. 22 And the servant said, Lord, it is done as thou hast commanded, and yet there is room. 23 And the lord said unto the servant, Go out into the highways and hedges, and compel *them* to come in, that my house may be filled. 24 For I say unto you, That none of those men which were bidden shall taste of my supper.

The excuses are ordinary: land, oxen, a wife. Ordinary things can keep us from the feast.

19 The Lost Sheep and the Lost Coin LUKE 15:3–10

> 3 And he spake this parable unto them, saying, 4 What man of you, having an hundred sheep, if he lose one of them, doth not leave the ninety and nine in the wilderness, and go after that which is lost, until he find it? 5 And when he hath found *it*, he layeth *it* on his shoulders, rejoicing. 6 And when he cometh home, he calleth together *his* friends and neighbours, saying unto them, Rejoice with me; for I have found my sheep which was lost. 7 I say unto you, that likewise joy shall be in heaven over one sinner that repenteth, more than over ninety and nine just persons, which need no repentance. 8 Either what woman having ten pieces of silver, if she lose one piece, doth not light a candle, and sweep the house, and seek diligently till she find *it*? 9 And when she hath found *it*, she calleth *her* friends and *her* neighbours together, saying, Rejoice with me; for I have found the piece which I had lost. 10 Likewise, I say unto you, there is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner that repenteth.

Heaven rejoices over one sinner who repents. The seeker does the searching.

20 The Prodigal Son LUKE 15:11–32

> 11 And he said, A certain man had two sons: 12 And the younger of them said to *his* father, Father, give me the portion of goods that falleth *to me*. And he divided unto them *his* living. 13 And not many days after the younger son gathered all together, and took his

journey into a far country, and there wasted his substance with riotous living. 14 And when he had spent all, there arose a mighty famine in that land; and he began to be in want. 15 And he went and joined himself to a citizen of that country; and he sent him into his fields to feed swine. 16 And he would fain have filled his belly with the husks that the swine did eat: and no man gave unto him. 17 And when he came to himself, he said, How many hired servants of my father's have bread enough and to spare, and I perish with hunger! 18 I will arise and go to my father, and will say unto him, Father, I have sinned against heaven, and before thee, 19 And am no more worthy to be called thy son: make me as one of thy hired servants. 20 And he arose, and came to his father. But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him. 21 And the son said unto him, Father, I have sinned against heaven, and in thy sight, and am no more worthy to be called thy son. 22 But the father said to his servants, Bring forth the best robe, and put *it* on him; and put a ring on his hand, and shoes on *his* feet: 23 And bring hither the fatted calf, and kill *it;* and let us eat, and be merry: 24 For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found. And they began to be merry. 25 Now his elder son was in the field: and as he came and drew nigh to the house, he heard musick and dancing. 26 And he called one of the servants, and asked what these things meant. 27 And he said unto him, Thy brother is come; and thy father hath killed the fatted calf, because he hath received him safe and sound. 28 And he was angry, and would not go in: therefore came his father out, and intreated him. 29 And he answering said to *his* father, Lo, these many years do I serve thee, neither transgressed I at any time thy commandment: and yet thou never gavest me a kid, that I might make merry with my friends: 30 But as soon as this thy son was come, which hath devoured thy living with harlots, thou hast killed for him the fatted calf. 31 And he said unto him, Son, thou art ever with me, and all that I have is thine. 32 It was meet that we should make merry, and be glad: for this thy brother was dead, and is alive again; and was lost, and is found.

Two lost sons: one in the far country, one at home in the field. The father runs to the first and goes out to plead with the second.

21 The Unjust Steward LUKE 16:1–13

1 And he said also unto his disciples, There was a certain rich man, which had a steward; and the same was accused unto him that he had wasted his goods. 2 And he called him, and said unto him, How is it that I hear this of thee? give an account of thy stewardship; for thou mayest be no longer steward. 3 Then the steward said within himself, What shall I do? for my lord taketh away from me the stewardship: I cannot dig; to beg I am ashamed. 4 I am resolved what to do, that, when I am put out of the stewardship, they may receive me into their houses. 5 So he called every one of his

lord's debtors *unto him*, and said unto the first, How much owest thou unto my lord?
6 And he said, An hundred measures of oil. And he said unto him, Take thy bill, and sit
down quickly, and write fifty. 7 Then said he to another, And how much owest thou?
And he said, An hundred measures of wheat. And he said unto him, Take thy bill, and
write fourscore. 8 And the lord commended the unjust steward, because he had done
wisely: for the children of this world are in their generation wiser than the children of
light. 9 And I say unto you, Make to yourselves friends of the mammon of
unrighteousness; that, when ye fail, they may receive you into everlasting habitations.
10 He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much: and he that is unjust
in the least is unjust also in much. 11 If therefore ye have not been faithful in the
unrighteous mammon, who will commit to your trust the true *riches*? 12 And if ye have
not been faithful in that which is another man's, who shall give you that which is your
own? 13 No servant can serve two masters: for either he will hate the one, and love the
other; or else he will hold to the one, and despise the other. Ye cannot serve God and
mammon.

A shrewd manager is commended for foresight, not dishonesty. Use what is passing for what is eternal.

22 The Rich Man and Lazarus LUKE 16:19–31

19 There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared
sumptuously every day: 20 And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was
laid at his gate, full of sores, 21 And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from
the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores. 22 And it came to
pass, that the beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom: the
rich man also died, and was buried; 23 And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments,
and seeth Abraham afar off, and Lazarus in his bosom. 24 And he cried and said, Father
Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in
water, and cool my tongue; for I am tormented in this flame. 25 But Abraham said, Son,
remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things, and likewise Lazarus
evil things: but now he is comforted, and thou art tormented. 26 And beside all this,
between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they which would pass from
hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that *would come* from thence. 27 Then
he said, I pray thee therefore, father, that thou wouldest send him to my father's house:
28 For I have five brethren; that he may testify unto them, lest they also come into this
place of torment. 29 Abraham saith unto him, They have Moses and the prophets; let
them hear them. 30 And he said, Nay, father Abraham: but if one went unto them from

> the dead, they will repent. 31 And he said unto him, If they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead.

The only parable where a character is named. A sobering look at eternity and at the sufficiency of Scripture: 'They have Moses and the prophets.'

23 The Persistent Widow LUKE 18:1–8

> 1 And he spake a parable unto them *to this end*, that men ought always to pray, and not to faint; 2 Saying, There was in a city a judge, which feared not God, neither regarded man: 3 And there was a widow in that city; and she came unto him, saying, Avenge me of mine adversary. 4 And he would not for a while: but afterward he said within himself, Though I fear not God, nor regard man; 5 Yet because this widow troubleth me, I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me. 6 And the Lord said, Hear what the unjust judge saith. 7 And shall not God avenge his own elect, which cry day and night unto him, though he bear long with them? 8 I tell you that he will avenge them speedily. Nevertheless when the Son of man cometh, shall he find faith on the earth?

Told so that 'men ought always to pray, and not to faint.'

24 The Pharisee and the Publican LUKE 18:9–14

> 9 And he spake this parable unto certain which trusted in themselves that they were righteous, and despised others: 10 Two men went up into the temple to pray; the one a Pharisee, and the other a publican. 11 The Pharisee stood and prayed thus with himself, God, I thank thee, that I am not as other men *are*, extortioners, unjust, adulterers, or even as this publican. 12 I fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess. 13 And the publican, standing afar off, would not lift up so much as *his* eyes unto heaven, but smote upon his breast, saying, God be merciful to me a sinner. 14 I tell you, this man went down to his house justified *rather* than the other: for every one that exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

One prays about himself; the other prays for mercy. Only one goes home justified.

For reflection

1. Which parable speaks most to your current season? What is it asking of you?

2. In the Prodigal Son, are you more like the younger brother or the elder? What does the father say to you?

3. Several parables describe servants entrusted with something. What has God entrusted to you?

STUDY 5 · SEVEN PORTRAITS IN JOHN

The "I AM" Sayings

When God revealed His name to Moses at the burning bush, He said 'I AM THAT I AM.' In John's Gospel Jesus takes that same name and joins it to seven pictures of what He is for us. Each one meets a deep human need.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 8:58

Jesus said unto them, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Before Abraham was, I am.

1 The name of God EXODUS 3:14

> And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM: and he said, Thus shalt thou say unto the children of Israel, I AM hath sent me unto you.

The background to every 'I am' in John.

2 Before Abraham was, I am JOHN 8:56–59

> 56 Your father Abraham rejoiced to see my day: and he saw it, and was glad. 57 Then said the Jews unto him, Thou art not yet fifty years old, and hast thou seen Abraham?
> 58 Jesus said unto them, Verily, verily, I say unto you, Before Abraham was, I am. 59 Then took they up stones to cast at him: but Jesus hid himself, and went out of the temple, going through the midst of them, and so passed by.

Jesus does not say 'I was' but 'I am'. His hearers understood: they took up stones.

3 I am the bread of life JOHN 6:35

> And Jesus said unto them, I am the bread of life: he that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst.

Spoken the day after He fed five thousand. He satisfies the hunger beneath every hunger.

4 I am the light of the world JOHN 8:12

> Then spake Jesus again unto them, saying, I am the light of the world: he that

> followeth me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life.

Spoken during the Feast of Tabernacles, when great lamps lit the temple courts. Then He gave sight to a man born blind (John 9).

5 I am the door JOHN 10:9

> I am the door: by me if any man enter in, he shall be saved, and shall go in and out, and find pasture.

One way in, and inside there is safety and pasture.

6 I am the good shepherd JOHN 10:11–15

> 11 I am the good shepherd: the good shepherd giveth his life for the sheep. 12 But he that is an hireling, and not the shepherd, whose own the sheep are not, seeth the wolf coming, and leaveth the sheep, and fleeth: and the wolf catcheth them, and scattereth the sheep. 13 The hireling fleeth, because he is an hireling, and careth not for the sheep. 14 I am the good shepherd, and know my *sheep*, and am known of mine. 15 As the Father knoweth me, even so know I the Father: and I lay down my life for the sheep.

Hirelings run. The good shepherd lays down His life for the sheep, and knows each one.

7 I am the resurrection, and the life JOHN 11:25–26

> 25 Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: 26 And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die. Believest thou this?

Said to a grieving sister before He raised her brother. Then the question to Martha, and to us: 'Believest thou this?'

8 I am the way, the truth, and the life JOHN 14:6

> Jesus saith unto him, I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me.

Thomas asked for directions. Jesus answered that He Himself is the road and the destination.

9 I am the true vine JOHN 15:1–5

> 1 I am the true vine, and my Father is the husbandman. 2 Every branch in me that beareth not fruit he taketh away: and every *branch* that beareth fruit, he purgeth it, that it may bring forth more fruit. 3 Now ye are clean through the word which I have spoken unto you. 4 Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me. 5 I am the vine, ye *are* the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: for without me ye can do nothing.

Fruit is not produced by effort but by abiding. Without Him, nothing.

For reflection

1. Which 'I am' meets the need you feel most right now?

2. What does it mean for you, practically, to 'abide' in the vine this week?

3. Jesus asked Martha, 'Believest thou this?' How do you answer?

STUDY 6 · MIRACLES THAT POINT TO JESUS IN JOHN

The Seven Signs

John calls Jesus' miracles 'signs' because each one points beyond itself to who He is. John chose seven, and tells us exactly why he wrote them down.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 20:31

But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

1 Water into wine JOHN 2:1–11

> 1 And the third day there was a marriage in Cana of Galilee; and the mother of Jesus was
> there: 2 And both Jesus was called, and his disciples, to the marriage. 3 And when they
> wanted wine, the mother of Jesus saith unto him, They have no wine. 4 Jesus saith unto
> her, Woman, what have I to do with thee? mine hour is not yet come. 5 His mother saith
> unto the servants, Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it. 6 And there were set there six
> waterpots of stone, after the manner of the purifying of the Jews, containing two or
> three firkins apiece. 7 Jesus saith unto them, Fill the waterpots with water. And they
> filled them up to the brim. 8 And he saith unto them, Draw out now, and bear unto the
> governor of the feast. And they bare it. 9 When the ruler of the feast had tasted the
> water that was made wine, and knew not whence it was: (but the servants which drew
> the water knew;) the governor of the feast called the bridegroom, 10 And saith unto
> him, Every man at the beginning doth set forth good wine; and when men have well
> drunk, then that which is worse: *but* thou hast kept the good wine until now. 11 This
> beginning of miracles did Jesus in Cana of Galilee, and manifested forth his glory; and
> his disciples believed on him.

The first sign, at a wedding. Water for ceremonial washing becomes the best wine: the new joy Jesus brings.

2 The nobleman's son healed JOHN 4:46–54

> 46 So Jesus came again into Cana of Galilee, where he made the water wine. And there
> was a certain nobleman, whose son was sick at Capernaum. 47 When he heard that
> Jesus was come out of Judaea into Galilee, he went unto him, and besought him that he
> would come down, and heal his son: for he was at the point of death. 48 Then said Jesus
> unto him, Except ye see signs and wonders, ye will not believe. 49 The nobleman saith

unto him, Sir, come down ere my child die. [50] Jesus saith unto him, Go thy way; thy son liveth. And the man believed the word that Jesus had spoken unto him, and he went his way. [51] And as he was now going down, his servants met him, and told *him*, saying, Thy son liveth. [52] Then enquired he of them the hour when he began to amend. And they said unto him, Yesterday at the seventh hour the fever left him. [53] So the father knew that *it was* at the same hour, in the which Jesus said unto him, Thy son liveth: and himself believed, and his whole house. [54] This *is* again the second miracle *that* Jesus did, when he was come out of Judaea into Galilee.

Healed at a distance by a word. The father 'believed the word' before he saw the result.

3 The man at Bethesda JOHN 5:5–9

[5] And a certain man was there, which had an infirmity thirty and eight years. [6] When Jesus saw him lie, and knew that he had been now a long time *in that case*, he saith unto him, Wilt thou be made whole? [7] The impotent man answered him, Sir, I have no man, when the water is troubled, to put me into the pool: but while I am coming, another steppeth down before me. [8] Jesus saith unto him, Rise, take up thy bed, and walk. [9] And immediately the man was made whole, and took up his bed, and walked: and on the same day was the sabbath.

Thirty-eight years of waiting ended by one command: Rise, take up thy bed, and walk.

4 Five thousand fed JOHN 6:5–14

[5] When Jesus then lifted up *his* eyes, and saw a great company come unto him, he saith unto Philip, Whence shall we buy bread, that these may eat? [6] And this he said to prove him: for he himself knew what he would do. [7] Philip answered him, Two hundred pennyworth of bread is not sufficient for them, that every one of them may take a little. [8] One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, saith unto him, [9] There is a lad here, which hath five barley loaves, and two small fishes: but what are they among so many? [10] And Jesus said, Make the men sit down. Now there was much grass in the place. So the men sat down, in number about five thousand. [11] And Jesus took the loaves; and when he had given thanks, he distributed to the disciples, and the disciples to them that were set down; and likewise of the fishes as much as they would. [12] When they were filled, he said unto his disciples, Gather up the fragments that remain, that nothing be lost. [13] Therefore they gathered *them* together, and filled twelve baskets with the fragments of the five barley loaves, which remained over and above unto them that

had eaten. 14 Then those men, when they had seen the miracle that Jesus did, said, This is of a truth that prophet that should come into the world.

A boy's lunch in the hands of Jesus. The sign leads to His teaching on the Bread of Life.

5 Walking on the water JOHN 6:16–21

16 And when even was *now* come, his disciples went down unto the sea, 17 And entered into a ship, and went over the sea toward Capernaum. And it was now dark, and Jesus was not come to them. 18 And the sea arose by reason of a great wind that blew. 19 So when they had rowed about five and twenty or thirty furlongs, they see Jesus walking on the sea, and drawing nigh unto the ship: and they were afraid. 20 But he saith unto them, It is I; be not afraid. 21 Then they willingly received him into the ship: and immediately the ship was at the land whither they went.

In the dark and the storm, 'It is I; be not afraid.' Literally, 'I am.'

6 The man born blind JOHN 9:1–7

1 And as *Jesus* passed by, he saw a man which was blind from *his* birth. 2 And his disciples asked him, saying, Master, who did sin, this man, or his parents, that he was born blind? 3 Jesus answered, Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him. 4 I must work the works of him that sent me, while it is day: the night cometh, when no man can work. 5 As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world. 6 When he had thus spoken, he spat on the ground, and made clay of the spittle, and he anointed the eyes of the blind man with the clay, 7 And said unto him, Go, wash in the pool of Siloam, (which is by interpretation, Sent.) He went his way therefore, and washed, and came seeing.

Not a punishment, but an occasion for 'the works of God' to be shown. Read the whole chapter: the man sees more clearly with every step while the Pharisees grow blinder.

7 Lazarus raised JOHN 11:38–44

38 Jesus therefore again groaning in himself cometh to the grave. It was a cave, and a stone lay upon it. 39 Jesus said, Take ye away the stone. Martha, the sister of him that was dead, saith unto him, Lord, by this time he stinketh: for he hath been *dead* four days. 40 Jesus saith unto her, Said I not unto thee, that, if thou wouldest believe, thou shouldest see the glory of God? 41 Then they took away the stone *from the place* where the dead was laid. And Jesus lifted up *his* eyes, and said, Father, I thank thee that thou

> hast heard me. 42 And I knew that thou hearest me always: but because of the people which stand by I said it, that they may believe that thou hast sent me. 43 And when he thus had spoken, he cried with a loud voice, Lazarus, come forth. 44 And he that was dead came forth, bound hand and foot with graveclothes: and his face was bound about with a napkin. Jesus saith unto them, Loose him, and let him go.

The greatest sign, four days after death. 'Jesus wept' (11:35) stands beside 'Lazarus, come forth.'

8 Why John wrote JOHN 20:30–31

> 30 And many other signs truly did Jesus in the presence of his disciples, which are not written in this book: 31 But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

The signs are written so that you might believe and have life through His name.

For reflection

1. Which sign do you find most personal? Why?

2. In each sign someone has to trust Jesus' word before seeing. Where is He asking you to do that?

3. How do the signs build toward the cross and the empty tomb?

How Jesus Taught Us to Pray

The disciples never asked Jesus to teach them to preach or heal. They asked, 'Lord, teach us to pray.' They had watched Him rise before dawn, pray all night before choosing the Twelve, and pour out His soul in Gethsemane.

MEMORY VERSE · MARK 11:24

Therefore I say unto you, What things soever ye desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive *them*, and ye shall have*them*.

1 A great while before day MARK 1:35

> And in the morning, rising up a great while before day, he went out, and departed into a solitary place, and there prayed.

After a night of healing the whole city, Jesus seeks the Father in a solitary place.

2 All night in prayer LUKE 6:12–13

> 12 And it came to pass in those days, that he went out into a mountain to pray, and continued all night in prayer to God. 13 And when it was day, he called *unto him* his disciples: and of them he chose twelve, whom also he named apostles;

The biggest decisions of His ministry were made on His knees.

3 Lord, teach us to pray LUKE 11:1–4

> 1 And it came to pass, that, as he was praying in a certain place, when he ceased, one of his disciples said unto him, Lord, teach us to pray, as John also taught his disciples.
> 2 And he said unto them, When ye pray, say, Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth. 3 Give us day by day our daily bread. 4 And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us. And lead us not into temptation; but deliver us from evil.

Luke's shorter form of the Lord's Prayer, given in answer to a request.

4 Ask, and it shall be given LUKE 11:9–13

> 9 And I say unto you, Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it
> shall be opened unto you. 10 For every one that asketh receiveth; and he that seeketh
> findeth; and to him that knocketh it shall be opened. 11 If a son shall ask bread of any of
> you that is a father, will he give him a stone? or if *he ask* a fish, will he for a fish give him
> a serpent? 12 Or if he shall ask an egg, will he offer him a scorpion? 13 If ye then, being
> evil, know how to give good gifts unto your children: how much more shall *your*
> heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to them that ask him?

The greatest gift the Father gives is the Holy Spirit.

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5 Always pray, and not faint LUKE 18:1–8

> 1 And he spake a parable unto them *to this end*, that men ought always to pray, and not
> to faint; 2 Saying, There was in a city a judge, which feared not God, neither regarded
> man: 3 And there was a widow in that city; and she came unto him, saying, Avenge me
> of mine adversary. 4 And he would not for a while: but afterward he said within
> himself, Though I fear not God, nor regard man; 5 Yet because this widow troubleth me,
> I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me. 6 And the Lord said, Hear
> what the unjust judge saith. 7 And shall not God avenge his own elect, which cry day
> and night unto him, though he bear long with them? 8 I tell you that he will avenge
> them speedily. Nevertheless when the Son of man cometh, shall he find faith on the
> earth?

Persistence is not nagging an unwilling God. It is faith that keeps coming.

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6 God be merciful to me a sinner LUKE 18:10–14

> 10 Two men went up into the temple to pray; the one a Pharisee, and the other a
> publican. 11 The Pharisee stood and prayed thus with himself, God, I thank thee, that I
> am not as other men *are*, extortioners, unjust, adulterers, or even as this publican. 12 I
> fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess. 13 And the publican, standing
> afar off, would not lift up so much as *his* eyes unto heaven, but smote upon his breast,
> saying, God be merciful to me a sinner. 14 I tell you, this man went down to his house
> justified *rather* than the other: for every one that exalteth himself shall be abased; and
> he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

The prayer God hears is humble.

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7 Not my will, but thine MATTHEW 26:36–46

> 36 Then cometh Jesus with them unto a place called Gethsemane, and saith unto the disciples, Sit ye here, while I go and pray yonder. 37 And he took with him Peter and the two sons of Zebedee, and began to be sorrowful and very heavy. 38 Then saith he unto them, My soul is exceeding sorrowful, even unto death: tarry ye here, and watch with me. 39 And he went a little farther, and fell on his face, and prayed, saying, O my Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me: nevertheless not as I will, but as thou *wilt*. 40 And he cometh unto the disciples, and findeth them asleep, and saith unto Peter, What, could ye not watch with me one hour? 41 Watch and pray, that ye enter not into temptation: the spirit indeed *is* willing, but the flesh *is* weak. 42 He went away again the second time, and prayed, saying, O my Father, if this cup may not pass away from me, except I drink it, thy will be done. 43 And he came and found them asleep again: for their eyes were heavy. 44 And he left them, and went away again, and prayed the third time, saying the same words. 45 Then cometh he to his disciples, and saith unto them, Sleep on now, and take *your* rest: behold, the hour is at hand, and the Son of man is betrayed into the hands of sinners. 46 Rise, let us be going: behold, he is at hand that doth betray me.

The most honest prayer ever prayed. Jesus asks for the cup to pass, and then surrenders.

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8 Jesus prays for you JOHN 17:20–23

> 20 Neither pray I for these alone, but for them also which shall believe on me through their word; 21 That they all may be one; as thou, Father, *art* in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me. 22 And the glory which thou gavest me I have given them; that they may be one, even as we are one: 23 I in them, and thou in me, that they may be made perfect in one; and that the world may know that thou hast sent me, and hast loved them, as thou hast loved me.

On the night before the cross, Jesus prays for 'them also which shall believe on me through their word.' That is you.

For reflection

1. What pattern of prayer do you see in Jesus' life? What could you adopt?

2. Pray through the Lord's Prayer, adding your own words to each line.

3. What does it mean to you that Jesus prayed for you by name in John 17?

The Greatest Commandment

When asked which commandment was greatest, Jesus quoted two from the Law of Moses and said everything else hangs on them. He then showed what love looks like and gave His disciples a new commandment: love as I have loved you.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 13:34

A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another.

1 The question MATTHEW 22:35–40

> 35 Then one of them, *which was* a lawyer, asked *him a question*, tempting him, and
> saying, 36 Master, which *is* the great commandment in the law? 37 Jesus said unto him,
> Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all
> thy mind. 38 This is the first and great commandment. 39 And the second *is* like unto it,
> Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. 40 On these two commandments hang all the
> law and the prophets.

All the law and the prophets hang on these two commandments.

2 From the Law: love the LORD DEUTERONOMY 6:4–5

> 4 Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God *is* one LORD: 5 And thou shalt love the LORD thy God
> with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might.

The Shema, recited daily by faithful Jews. Jesus quotes it as the first commandment.

3 From the Law: love your neighbour LEVITICUS 19:18

> Thou shalt not avenge, nor bear any grudge against the children of thy people, but thou
> shalt love thy neighbour as thyself: I *am* the LORD.

Hidden among the laws of Leviticus, Jesus lifts it up beside the first.

4 Who is my neighbour? LUKE 10:29–37

> 29 But he, willing to justify himself, said unto Jesus, And who is my neighbour? 30 And
> Jesus answering said, A certain *man* went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell
> among thieves, which stripped him of his raiment, and wounded *him,* and departed,
> leaving *him* half dead. 31 And by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and
> when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. 32 And likewise a Levite, when he was
> at the place, came and looked *on him,* and passed by on the other side. 33 But a certain
> Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was: and when he saw him, he had
> compassion *on him,* 34 And went to *him,* and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and
> wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him.
> 35 And on the morrow when he departed, he took out two pence, and gave *them* to the
> host, and said unto him, Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I
> come again, I will repay thee. 36 Which now of these three, thinkest thou, was
> neighbour unto him that fell among the thieves? 37 And he said, He that shewed mercy
> on him. Then said Jesus unto him, Go, and do thou likewise.

The hero is a Samaritan, the man the lawyer would least expect.

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5 Love your enemies LUKE 6:27–36

> 27 But I say unto you which hear, Love your enemies, do good to them which hate you,
> 28 Bless them that curse you, and pray for them which despitefully use you. 29 And unto
> him that smiteth thee on the *one* cheek offer also the other; and him that taketh away
> thy cloke forbid not *to take thy* coat also. 30 Give to every man that asketh of thee; and of
> him that taketh away thy goods ask *them* not again. 31 And as ye would that men should
> do to you, do ye also to them likewise. 32 For if ye love them which love you, what thank
> have ye? for sinners also love those that love them. 33 And if ye do good to them which
> do good to you, what thank have ye? for sinners also do even the same. 34 And if ye lend
> *to them* of whom ye hope to receive, what thank have ye? for sinners also lend to
> sinners, to receive as much again. 35 But love ye your enemies, and do good, and lend,
> hoping for nothing again; and your reward shall be great, and ye shall be the children
> of the Highest: for he is kind unto the unthankful and to the evil. 36 Be ye therefore
> merciful, as your Father also is merciful.

Love that expects nothing back is the family likeness of the Most High.

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6 A new commandment JOHN 13:34–35

> 34 A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. 35 By this shall all *men* know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.

What is new is the standard: 'as I have loved you.' He had just washed their feet.

7 Greater love hath no man JOHN 15:12–14

> 12 This is my commandment, That ye love one another, as I have loved you. 13 Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friends. 14 Ye are my friends, if ye do whatsoever I command you.

Love is defined by the cross.

8 Ye did it unto me MATTHEW 25:34–40

> 34 Then shall the King say unto them on his right hand, Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world: 35 For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in: 36 Naked, and ye clothed me: I was sick, and ye visited me: I was in prison, and ye came unto me. 37 Then shall the righteous answer him, saying, Lord, when saw we thee an hungred, and fed *thee*? or thirsty, and gave *thee* drink? 38 When saw we thee a stranger, and took *thee* in? or naked, and clothed *thee*? 39 Or when saw we thee sick, or in prison, and came unto thee? 40 And the King shall answer and say unto them, Verily I say unto you, Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me.

Love for the least is received by the King as love for Himself.

For reflection

1. Who is the 'neighbour' God has put in your path that you have been passing by?

2. Jesus loved by serving (John 13). What is one act of humble service you can do this week?

3. Is there someone you find hard to love? Pray for them by name.

STUDY 9 · THE HEART OF JESUS' MESSAGE

The Kingdom of Heaven

Jesus' first sermon was one sentence long: the kingdom of God is at hand. The kingdom is God's reign breaking into the world through Jesus Himself. It is present now in hidden ways and will come in fullness when He returns.

MEMORY VERSE · MATTHEW 6:33

But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

1 The kingdom is at hand MARK 1:14–15

> 14 Now after that John was put in prison, Jesus came into Galilee, preaching the gospel of the kingdom of God, 15 And saying, The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel.

The time is fulfilled. The right response is to repent and believe.

2 Ye must be born again JOHN 3:3–7

> 3 Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God. 4 Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born? 5 Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God. 6 That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. 7 Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again.

Entrance into the kingdom requires a new birth from above, by water and the Spirit.

3 Seek ye first MATTHEW 6:33

> But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

The kingdom is not one priority among many. It orders all the others.

4 Within you LUKE 17:20–21

> 20 And when he was demanded of the Pharisees, when the kingdom of God should come, he answered them and said, The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: 21 Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.

Or 'in your midst'. The King was standing among them.

5 As a little child MATTHEW 18:1–4

> 1 At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus, saying, Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven? 2 And Jesus called a little child unto him, and set him in the midst of them, 3 And said, Verily I say unto you, Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven. 4 Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven.

Greatness in the kingdom looks like childlike humility and dependence.

6 Not of this world JOHN 18:36–37

> 36 Jesus answered, My kingdom is not of this world: if my kingdom were of this world, then would my servants fight, that I should not be delivered to the Jews: but now is my kingdom not from hence. 37 Pilate therefore said unto him, Art thou a king then? Jesus answered, Thou sayest that I am a king. To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world, that I should bear witness unto the truth. Every one that is of the truth heareth my voice.

Spoken to Pilate. His kingdom does not advance by the sword but by the truth.

7 Doing the will of the Father MATTHEW 7:21

> Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven.

Saying 'Lord, Lord' is not the same as living under His lordship.

8 Thy kingdom come MATTHEW 6:10

> Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.

Every time we pray this, we ask for heaven's will to be done here.

For reflection

1. What areas of your life are not yet fully under the reign of King Jesus?

2. What does 'seek ye first the kingdom' look like in your schedule and finances?

3. How does knowing the King is coming again shape the way you live now?

STUDY 10 · THE CALL AND COST OF DISCIPLESHIP

Follow Me

Jesus' invitation is simple: 'Follow me.' It began at the seashore and it ended at the seashore, when the risen Lord said it to Peter again. In between, Jesus was honest about the cost and generous with the reward.

MEMORY VERSE · LUKE 9:23

And he said to *them* all, If any *man* will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me.

1 Fishers of men MATTHEW 4:18–22

> 18 And Jesus, walking by the sea of Galilee, saw two brethren, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea: for they were fishers. 19 And he saith unto them, Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men. 20 And they straightway left *their* nets, and followed him. 21 And going on from thence, he saw other two brethren, James *the son* of Zebedee, and John his brother, in a ship with Zebedee their father, mending their nets; and he called them. 22 And they immediately left the ship and their father, and followed him.

They left their nets 'straightway'. Following begins with leaving.

2 Come unto me MATTHEW 11:28–30

> 28 Come unto me, all *ye* that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. 29 Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. 30 For my yoke *is* easy, and my burden is light.

The call to follow is also a call to rest. His yoke is easy.

3 Take up the cross daily LUKE 9:23–26

> 23 And he said to *them* all, If any *man* will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me. 24 For whosoever will save his life shall lose it: but whosoever will lose his life for my sake, the same shall save it. 25 For what is a man advantaged, if he gain the whole world, and lose himself, or be cast away? 26 For whosoever shall be ashamed of me and of my words, of him shall the Son of man be

> ashamed, when he shall come in his own glory, and *in his* Father's, and of the holy angels.

The cross was an instrument of death. To follow is to die to self every day.

4 Count the cost LUKE 14:27–33

> 27 And whosoever doth not bear his cross, and come after me, cannot be my disciple.
> 28 For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have *sufficient* to finish *it*? 29 Lest haply, after he hath laid the foundation, and is not able to finish *it*, all that behold *it* begin to mock him, 30 Saying, This man began to build, and was not able to finish. 31 Or what king, going to make war against another king, sitteth not down first, and consulteth whether he be able with ten thousand to meet him that cometh against him with twenty thousand? 32 Or else, while the other is yet a great way off, he sendeth an ambassage, and desireth conditions of peace. 33 So likewise, whosoever he be of you that forsaketh not all that he hath, he cannot be my disciple.

Jesus wants informed disciples, not impulsive ones.

5 Abide in me JOHN 15:4–8

> 4 Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me. 5 I am the vine, ye *are* the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: for without me ye can do nothing. 6 If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them, and cast *them* into the fire, and they are burned. 7 If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you. 8 Herein is my Father glorified, that ye bear much fruit; so shall ye be my disciples.

The secret of fruitfulness is staying connected to the vine.

6 Not to be ministered unto MARK 10:42–45

> 42 But Jesus called them *to him*, and saith unto them, Ye know that they which are accounted to rule over the Gentiles exercise lordship over them; and their great ones exercise authority upon them. 43 But so shall it not be among you: but whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister: 44 And whosoever of you will be the

> chiefest, shall be servant of all. 45 For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

Greatness is service. The Son of Man came to give His life as a ransom.

7 Lovest thou me? JOHN 21:15–19

> 15 So when they had dined, Jesus saith to Simon Peter, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my lambs. 16 He saith to him again the second time, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my sheep. 17 He saith unto him the third time, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me? Peter was grieved because he said unto him the third time, Lovest thou me? And he said unto him, Lord, thou knowest all things; thou knowest that I love thee. Jesus saith unto him, Feed my sheep. 18 Verily, verily, I say unto thee, When thou wast young, thou girdedst thyself, and walkedst whither thou wouldest: but when thou shalt be old, thou shalt stretch forth thy hands, and another shall gird thee, and carry *thee* whither thou wouldest not. 19 This spake he, signifying by what death he should glorify God. And when he had spoken this, he saith unto him, Follow me.

Three denials, three questions, three commissions. Then, once more: 'Follow me.'

8 Go ye therefore MATTHEW 28:18–20

> 18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, *even* unto the end of the world. Amen.

Disciples make disciples, and He is with us always, even unto the end of the world.

For reflection

1. What 'nets' might Jesus be asking you to leave behind?

2. Where do you need His rest more than more effort?

3. Who could you help to follow Jesus this year?

STUDY 11 · LAST WORDS OF THE SAVIOUR

The Seven Sayings from the Cross

The four Gospels together record seven things Jesus said from the cross. They reveal His forgiveness, His saving power, His care, His suffering, His humanity, His finished work, and His trust in the Father. Read them slowly, and remember they were spoken for you.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 19:30

When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, It is finished: and he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost.

1 Why He came to die MARK 10:45

> For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

The cross was not an accident. He came to give His life a ransom for many.

2 He laid it down JOHN 10:17–18

> 17 Therefore doth my Father love me, because I lay down my life, that I might take it again. 18 No man taketh it from me, but I lay it down of myself. I have power to lay it down, and I have power to take it again. This commandment have I received of my Father.

No man took His life from Him. He gave it.

3 Wounded for our transgressions ISAIAH 53:4–6

> 4 Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows: yet we did esteem him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted. 5 But he *was* wounded for our transgressions, *he was* bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace *was* upon him; and with his stripes we are healed. 6 All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD hath laid on him the iniquity of us all.

Seven centuries earlier, Isaiah described the suffering Servant.

4

1. Father, forgive them LUKE 23:33–34

> 33 And when they were come to the place, which is called Calvary, there they crucified him, and the malefactors, one on the right hand, and the other on the left. 34 Then said Jesus, Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do. And they parted his raiment, and cast lots.

His first words from the cross are a prayer for His executioners.

5

2. Today shalt thou be with me in paradise LUKE 23:39–43

> 39 And one of the malefactors which were hanged railed on him, saying, If thou be Christ, save thyself and us. 40 But the other answering rebuked him, saying, Dost not thou fear God, seeing thou art in the same condemnation? 41 And we indeed justly; for we receive the due reward of our deeds: but this man hath done nothing amiss. 42 And he said unto Jesus, Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom. 43 And Jesus said unto him, Verily I say unto thee, To day shalt thou be with me in paradise.

A dying thief with nothing to offer receives the promise of paradise.

6

3. Woman, behold thy son! JOHN 19:25–27

> 25 Now there stood by the cross of Jesus his mother, and his mother's sister, Mary the *wife* of Cleophas, and Mary Magdalene. 26 When Jesus therefore saw his mother, and the disciple standing by, whom he loved, he saith unto his mother, Woman, behold thy son! 27 Then saith he to the disciple, Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own *home*.

In agony He provides for His mother and entrusts her to John.

7

4. My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? MATTHEW 27:45–46

> 45 Now from the sixth hour there was darkness over all the land unto the ninth hour. 46 And about the ninth hour Jesus cried with a loud voice, saying, Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani? that is to say, My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

He quotes Psalm 22:1. In the darkness He bore our sin and its separation.

8

5. I thirst JOHN 19:28–29

> 28 After this, Jesus knowing that all things were now accomplished, that the scripture might be fulfilled, saith, I thirst. 29 Now there was set a vessel full of vinegar: and they filled a spunge with vinegar, and put it upon hyssop, and put it to his mouth.

The Creator of rivers suffered real thirst, 'that the scripture might be fulfilled.'

9

6. It is finished JOHN 19:30

> When Jesus therefore had received the vinegar, he said, It is finished: and he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost.

One word in Greek, tetelestai, used of a debt paid in full.

10

7. Father, into thy hands LUKE 23:44–47

> 44 And it was about the sixth hour, and there was a darkness over all the earth until the ninth hour. 45 And the sun was darkened, and the veil of the temple was rent in the midst. 46 And when Jesus had cried with a loud voice, he said, Father, into thy hands I commend my spirit: and having said thus, he gave up the ghost. 47 Now when the centurion saw what was done, he glorified God, saying, Certainly this was a righteous man.

He dies trusting, quoting Psalm 31:5, and a Roman centurion glorifies God.

For reflection

1. Which saying from the cross moves you most deeply? Why?

2. 'Father, forgive them.' Is there someone you need to forgive in the light of the cross?

3. What does 'It is finished' mean for any guilt you still carry?

STUDY 12 · THE RESURRECTION APPEARANCES

He Is Risen

Every Gospel ends with an empty tomb. The resurrection is the Father's 'Amen' to everything Jesus said and did. Watch how the risen Lord meets each person: weeping Mary, discouraged travellers, doubting Thomas, failed Peter.

MEMORY VERSE · MATTHEW 28:6

He is not here: for he is risen, as he said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay.

1 He is not here MATTHEW 28:1–10

> 1 In the end of the sabbath, as it began to dawn toward the first *day* of the week, came
> Mary Magdalene and the other Mary to see the sepulchre. 2 And, behold, there was a
> great earthquake: for the angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and
> rolled back the stone from the door, and sat upon it. 3 His countenance was like
> lightning, and his raiment white as snow: 4 And for fear of him the keepers did shake,
> and became as dead *men*. 5 And the angel answered and said unto the women, Fear not
> ye: for I know that ye seek Jesus, which was crucified. 6 He is not here: for he is risen, as
> he said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay. 7 And go quickly, and tell his disciples
> that he is risen from the dead; and, behold, he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall
> ye see him: lo, I have told you. 8 And they departed quickly from the sepulchre with fear
> and great joy; and did run to bring his disciples word. 9 And as they went to tell his
> disciples, behold, Jesus met them, saying, All hail. And they came and held him by the
> feet, and worshipped him. 10 Then said Jesus unto them, Be not afraid: go tell my
> brethren that they go into Galilee, and there shall they see me.

The angel invites the women to come and see, then go and tell.

2 Mary JOHN 20:11–18

> 11 But Mary stood without at the sepulchre weeping: and as she wept, she stooped down,
> *and* looked into the sepulchre, 12 And seeth two angels in white sitting, the one at the
> head, and the other at the feet, where the body of Jesus had lain. 13 And they say unto
> her, Woman, why weepest thou? She saith unto them, Because they have taken away
> my Lord, and I know not where they have laid him. 14 And when she had thus said, she
> turned herself back, and saw Jesus standing, and knew not that it was Jesus. 15 Jesus
> saith unto her, Woman, why weepest thou? whom seekest thou? She, supposing him to

be the gardener, saith unto him, Sir, if thou have borne him hence, tell me where thou hast laid him, and I will take him away. 16 Jesus saith unto her, Mary. She turned herself, and saith unto him, Rabboni; which is to say, Master. 17 Jesus saith unto her, Touch me not; for I am not yet ascended to my Father: but go to my brethren, and say unto them, I ascend unto my Father, and your Father; and to my God, and your God. 18 Mary Magdalene came and told the disciples that she had seen the Lord, and *that* he had spoken these things unto her.

She recognised Him when He spoke her name.

3 The road to Emmaus LUKE 24:25–32

25 Then he said unto them, O fools, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken: 26 Ought not Christ to have suffered these things, and to enter into his glory? 27 And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself. 28 And they drew nigh unto the village, whither they went: and he made as though he would have gone further. 29 But they constrained him, saying, Abide with us: for it is toward evening, and the day is far spent. And he went in to tarry with them. 30 And it came to pass, as he sat at meat with them, he took bread, and blessed *it*, and brake, and gave to them. 31 And their eyes were opened, and they knew him; and he vanished out of their sight. 32 And they said one to another, Did not our heart burn within us, while he talked with us by the way, and while he opened to us the scriptures?

Jesus explains Himself from all the Scriptures. Their hearts burned within them.

4 Thus it is written LUKE 24:44–48

44 And he said unto them, These *are* the words which I spake unto you, while I was yet with you, that all things must be fulfilled, which were written in the law of Moses, and *in* the prophets, and *in* the psalms, concerning me. 45 Then opened he their understanding, that they might understand the scriptures, 46 And said unto them, Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day: 47 And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem. 48 And ye are witnesses of these things.

The Law, the Prophets and the Psalms all point to Him.

5 Thomas JOHN 20:24–29

> 24 But Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, was not with them when Jesus came.
> 25 The other disciples therefore said unto him, We have seen the Lord. But he said unto them, Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe. 26 And after eight days again his disciples were within, and Thomas with them: *then* came Jesus, the doors being shut, and stood in the midst, and said, Peace *be* unto you. 27 Then saith he to Thomas, reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust *it* into my side: and be not faithless, but believing. 28 And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God. 29 Jesus saith unto him, Thomas, because thou hast seen me, thou hast believed: blessed *are* they that have not seen, and *yet* have believed.

Jesus meets doubt with evidence and an invitation.

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6 Peter restored JOHN 21:15–17

> 15 So when they had dined, Jesus saith to Simon Peter, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my lambs. 16 He saith to him again the second time, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my sheep. 17 He saith unto him the third time, Simon, *son* of Jonas, lovest thou me? Peter was grieved because he said unto him the third time, Lovest thou me? And he said unto him, Lord, thou knowest all things; thou knowest that I love thee. Jesus saith unto him, Feed my sheep.

Grace does not ignore failure. It heals it.

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7 The Great Commission MATTHEW 28:18–20

> 18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, *even* unto the end of the world. Amen.

All power, all nations, all things, always.

For reflection

1. Why does the resurrection matter for your faith today?

2. Which resurrection encounter is most like your own story with Jesus?

3. Mary was told to 'go and tell'. Who could you tell about the risen Lord?

STUDY 13 · THE OLD TESTAMENT POINTS TO JESUS

That It Might Be Fulfilled

On the road to Emmaus Jesus began 'at Moses and all the prophets' and showed 'the things concerning himself.' Here are eleven Old Testament passages set beside their fulfilment in the Gospels, so you can read them side by side.

MEMORY VERSE · LUKE 24:27

And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself.

1 Born of a virgin ISAIAH 7:14 · MATTHEW 1:22–23

> Therefore the Lord himself shall give you a sign; Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.

> 22 Now all this was done, that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, 23 Behold, a virgin shall be with child, and shall bring forth a son, and they shall call his name Emmanuel, which being interpreted is, God with us.

Immanuel: God with us.

2 Unto us a child is born ISAIAH 9:6 · LUKE 2:10–11

> For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace.

> 10 And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. 11 For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.

The child is called 'The mighty God'.

3 Born in Bethlehem MICAH 5:2 · MATTHEW 2:4–6

> But thou, Bethlehem Ephratah, *though* thou be little among the thousands of Judah, *yet* out of thee shall he come forth unto me *that is* to be ruler in Israel; whose goings forth *have been* from of old, from everlasting.

> 4 And when he had gathered all the chief priests and scribes of the people together, he demanded of them where Christ should be born. 5 And they said unto him, In Bethlehem of Judaea: for thus it is written by the prophet, 6 And thou Bethlehem, in the land of Juda, art not the least among the princes of Juda: for out of thee shall come a Governor, that shall rule my people Israel.

The chief priests knew the answer to Herod's question at once.

4 Called out of Egypt HOSEA 11:1 · MATTHEW 2:14–15

> When Israel *was* a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt.

> 14 When he arose, he took the young child and his mother by night, and departed into Egypt: 15 And was there until the death of Herod: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Out of Egypt have I called my son.

Jesus relives Israel's story, and succeeds where Israel failed.

5 A voice in the wilderness ISAIAH 40:3 · MATTHEW 3:1–3

> The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the LORD, make straight in the desert a highway for our God.

> 1 In those days came John the Baptist, preaching in the wilderness of Judaea, 2 And saying, Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand. 3 For this is he that was spoken of by the prophet Esaias, saying, The voice of one crying in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the Lord, make his paths straight.

John the Baptist prepares the way of the LORD, and the LORD who comes is Jesus.

6 Anointed to preach ISAIAH 61:1–2 · LUKE 4:16–21

> [1] The Spirit of the Lord GOD *is* upon me; because the LORD hath anointed me to preach good tidings unto the meek; he hath sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to *them that are* bound; [2] To proclaim the acceptable year of the LORD, and the day of vengeance of our God; to comfort all that mourn;

> [16] And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up: and, as his custom was, he went into the synagogue on the sabbath day, and stood up for to read. [17] And there was delivered unto him the book of the prophet Esaias. And when he had opened the book, he found the place where it was written, [18] The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor; he hath sent me to heal the brokenhearted, to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised, [19] To preach the acceptable year of the Lord. [20] And he closed the book, and he gave *it* again to the minister, and sat down. And the eyes of all them that were in the synagogue were fastened on him. [21] And he began to say unto them, This day is this scripture fulfilled in your ears.

Jesus stops reading mid-sentence, before 'the day of vengeance'. This is the year of grace.

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7 Thy King cometh, riding upon an ass ZECHARIAH 9:9 · MATTHEW 21:4–9

> Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion; shout, O daughter of Jerusalem: behold, thy King cometh unto thee: he *is* just, and having salvation; lowly, and riding upon an ass, and upon a colt the foal of an ass.

> [4] All this was done, that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet, saying, [5] Tell ye the daughter of Sion, Behold, thy King cometh unto thee, meek, and sitting upon an ass, and a colt the foal of an ass. [6] And the disciples went, and did as Jesus commanded them, [7] And brought the ass, and the colt, and put on them their clothes, and they set *him* thereon. [8] And a very great multitude spread their garments in the way; others cut down branches from the trees, and strawed *them* in the way. [9] And the multitudes that went before, and that followed, cried, saying, Hosanna to the Son of David: Blessed *is* he that cometh in the name of the Lord; Hosanna in the highest.

A King who comes in humility.

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8 The stone which the builders refused PSALM 118:22–23 · MATTHEW 21:42

> 22 The stone *which* the builders refused is become the head *stone* of the corner. 23 This is the LORD'S doing; it *is* marvellous in our eyes.

> Jesus saith unto them, Did ye never read in the scriptures, The stone which the builders rejected, the same is become the head of the corner: this is the Lord's doing, and it is marvellous in our eyes?

Rejected by men, chosen by God.

9 They part my garments PSALM 22:18 · JOHN 19:23–24

> They part my garments among them, and cast lots upon my vesture.

> 23 Then the soldiers, when they had crucified Jesus, took his garments, and made four parts, to every soldier a part; and also *his* coat: now the coat was without seam, woven from the top throughout. 24 They said therefore among themselves, Let us not rend it, but cast lots for it, whose it shall be: that the scripture might be fulfilled, which saith, They parted my raiment among them, and for my vesture they did cast lots. These things therefore the soldiers did.

Soldiers fulfil Scripture without knowing it.

10 My God, my God PSALM 22:1 · MATTHEW 27:46

> My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? *why art thou so* far from helping me, *and from* the words of my roaring?

> And about the ninth hour Jesus cried with a loud voice, saying, Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani? that is to say, My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

Psalm 22 begins in forsakenness and ends in triumph.

11 He shall not see corruption PSALM 16:10 · LUKE 24:5–7

> For thou wilt not leave my soul in hell; neither wilt thou suffer thine Holy One to see corruption.

> [5] And as they were afraid, and bowed down *their* faces to the earth, they said unto them, Why seek ye the living among the dead? [6] He is not here, but is risen: remember how he spake unto you when he was yet in Galilee, [7] Saying, The Son of man must be delivered into the hands of sinful men, and be crucified, and the third day rise again.

He is not here, but is risen.

For reflection

1. Which fulfilled prophecy strengthens your faith most?

2. What does it tell you about God that He planned the coming of Jesus centuries ahead?

3. Read Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53 in full this week. What do you see of Jesus there?

The Life of Christ in the four Gospels

#	Event	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
1	The birth of Jesus	1:18-25	—	2:1-20	—
2	The boy Jesus in the temple	—	—	2:41-52	—
3	Baptized by John	3:13-17	1:9-11	3:21-22	1:29-34
4	Tempted in the wilderness	4:1-11	1:12-13	4:1-13	—
5	Water into wine at Cana	—	—	—	2:1-11
6	Nicodemus by night	—	—	—	3:1-21
7	The woman at the well	—	—	—	4:5-42
8	Rejected at Nazareth	13:54-58	6:1-6	4:16-30	—
9	Fishers of men	4:18-22	1:16-20	5:1-11	—
10	The Sermon on the Mount	5:1-7:29	—	6:17-49	—
11	The storm calmed	8:23-27	4:35-41	8:22-25	—
12	Five thousand fed	14:13-21	6:30-44	9:10-17	6:1-14
13	Walking on the water	14:22-33	6:45-52	—	6:16-21
14	Peter's confession	16:13-20	8:27-30	9:18-21	—
15	The Transfiguration	17:1-8	9:2-8	9:28-36	—
16	Lazarus raised	—	—	—	11:1-44
17	Zacchaeus	—	—	19:1-10	—
18	The triumphal entry	21:1-11	11:1-11	19:28-40	12:12-19
19	The temple cleansed	21:12-13	11:15-17	19:45-46	2:13-17
20	The Last Supper	26:17-30	14:12-26	22:7-23	13:1-30

#	Event	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
21	Gethsemane	26:36-46	14:32-42	22:39-46	—
22	The arrest	26:47-56	14:43-50	22:47-53	18:2-12
23	The crucifixion	27:32-56	15:21-41	23:26-49	19:16-37
24	The empty tomb	28:1-10	16:1-8	24:1-12	20:1-18
25	The Great Commission	28:16-20	16:15-18	—	—
26	The ascension	—	16:19-20	24:50-53	—

The Four Gospels: 89-day checklist

- [ ] 1 Matthew 1 The Genealogy and Birth of Jesus
- [ ] 2 Matthew 2 Wise Men and the Flight into Egypt
- [ ] 3 Matthew 3 John the Baptist; Jesus Is Baptized
- [ ] 4 Matthew 4 The Temptation; Fishers of Men
- [ ] 5 Matthew 5 The Sermon on the Mount: Blessed Are...
- [ ] 6 Matthew 6 The Sermon on the Mount: Prayer and Treasure
- [ ] 7 Matthew 7 The Sermon on the Mount: Ask, Seek, Knock
- [ ] 8 Matthew 8 Healing the Leper; Calming the Storm
- [ ] 9 Matthew 9 Matthew Called; Faith That Heals
- [ ] 10 Matthew 10 The Twelve Sent Out
- [ ] 11 Matthew 11 Come unto Me, All Ye That Labour
- [ ] 12 Matthew 12 Lord of the Sabbath
- [ ] 13 Matthew 13 Parables of the Kingdom
- [ ] 14 Matthew 14 Five Thousand Fed; Walking on the Water
- [ ] 15 Matthew 15 The Heart and the Canaanite Woman's Faith
- [ ] 16 Matthew 16 Thou Art the Christ
- [ ] 17 Matthew 17 The Transfiguration
- [ ] 18 Matthew 18 Greatest in the Kingdom; Forgive Seventy Times Seven
- [ ] 19 Matthew 19 Marriage, Children, and the Rich Young Man
- [ ] 20 Matthew 20 Labourers in the Vineyard; Came to Minister
- [ ] 21 Matthew 21 The King Comes to Jerusalem
- [ ] 22 Matthew 22 The Wedding Feast; The Great Commandment
- [ ] 23 Matthew 23 Woes to the Scribes and Pharisees
- [ ] 24 Matthew 24 Signs of the End of the Age
- [ ] 25 Matthew 25 The Ten Virgins, the Talents, the Sheep and Goats
- [ ] 26 Matthew 26 The Last Supper and Gethsemane
- [ ] 27 Matthew 27 The Trial and the Crucifixion
- [ ] 28 Matthew 28 He Is Risen; Go Ye Therefore
- [ ] 29 Mark 1 The Beginning of the Gospel
- [ ] 30 Mark 2 Authority to Forgive Sins
- [ ] 31 Mark 3 The Twelve Ordained
- [ ] 32 Mark 4 The Sower; Peace, Be Still
- [ ] 33 Mark 5 Legion; Jairus' Daughter
- [ ] 34 Mark 6 Rejected at Nazareth; Five Thousand Fed
- [ ] 35 Mark 7 Tradition and the Heart; Ephphatha
- [ ] 36 Mark 8 Whom Say Ye That I Am?

- [ ] 37 Mark 9 The Transfiguration; Lord, I Believe
- [ ] 38 Mark 10 Children, Riches, and Blind Bartimaeus
- [ ] 39 Mark 11 Hosanna; Have Faith in God
- [ ] 40 Mark 12 The Vineyard; The First Commandment; The Widow's Mites
- [ ] 41 Mark 13 Watch: The Coming of the Son of Man
- [ ] 42 Mark 14 Anointed at Bethany; Gethsemane
- [ ] 43 Mark 15 The King of the Jews Crucified
- [ ] 44 Mark 16 He Is Risen
- [ ] 45 Luke 1 Promises to Zacharias and to Mary
- [ ] 46 Luke 2 The Birth of Jesus; The Boy in the Temple
- [ ] 47 Luke 3 The Voice in the Wilderness
- [ ] 48 Luke 4 The Temptation; The Spirit of the Lord Is upon Me
- [ ] 49 Luke 5 Launch Out into the Deep
- [ ] 50 Luke 6 The Sermon on the Plain
- [ ] 51 Luke 7 The Centurion's Faith; The Woman Who Loved Much
- [ ] 52 Luke 8 The Sower; The Storm; Jairus' Daughter
- [ ] 53 Luke 9 The Twelve Sent; Take Up Thy Cross
- [ ] 54 Luke 10 The Good Samaritan; Mary and Martha
- [ ] 55 Luke 11 Lord, Teach Us to Pray
- [ ] 56 Luke 12 The Rich Fool; Take No Thought
- [ ] 57 Luke 13 Repent; The Strait Gate
- [ ] 58 Luke 14 The Great Supper; The Cost of Discipleship
- [ ] 59 Luke 15 The Lost Sheep, the Lost Coin, the Lost Son
- [ ] 60 Luke 16 The Steward; The Rich Man and Lazarus
- [ ] 61 Luke 17 Ten Lepers Cleansed
- [ ] 62 Luke 18 The Pharisee and the Publican
- [ ] 63 Luke 19 Zacchaeus; The Pounds; The Triumphal Entry
- [ ] 64 Luke 20 By What Authority?
- [ ] 65 Luke 21 The Widow's Two Mites; Signs of the End
- [ ] 66 Luke 22 The Last Supper; Not My Will
- [ ] 67 Luke 23 Father, Forgive Them
- [ ] 68 Luke 24 The Road to Emmaus
- [ ] 69 John 1 The Word Was Made Flesh
- [ ] 70 John 2 Water into Wine
- [ ] 71 John 3 Ye Must Be Born Again
- [ ] 72 John 4 The Woman at the Well
- [ ] 73 John 5 The Pool of Bethesda
- [ ] 74 John 6 The Bread of Life
- [ ] 75 John 7 Rivers of Living Water
- [ ] 76 John 8 The Light of the World
- [ ] 77 John 9 The Man Born Blind
- [ ] 78 John 10 The Good Shepherd

- [ ] 79 John 11 The Resurrection and the Life
- [ ] 80 John 12 The Hour Is Come
- [ ] 81 John 13 Washing the Disciples' Feet
- [ ] 82 John 14 The Way, the Truth, and the Life
- [ ] 83 John 15 The True Vine
- [ ] 84 John 16 The Comforter Will Come
- [ ] 85 John 17 Jesus Prays for His Own
- [ ] 86 John 18 Arrest and Trial
- [ ] 87 John 19 It Is Finished
- [ ] 88 John 20 The Empty Tomb; My Lord and My God
- [ ] 89 John 21 Lovest Thou Me? Feed My Sheep